Sagnik Kumar Gupta

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. (Development Studies), Indian Institute of Technology Hyderabad 2024–Present

Advisor: Dr. Gaurav Dhamija

M.Sc. (Population Studies & Health Economics), Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics, Maharashtra, India 2021–2023

B.Sc. (Economics Honours), University of Calcutta, West Bengal, India 2018–2021

WORKING PAPERS

- **Rewiring Gender Norms: Causal Evidence on Internet Exposure and Justification of Intimate Partner Violence**
  (with Dr. Gaurav Dhamija and Dr. Manini Ojha)
  Accepted for Publication, Forthcoming, Review of Economics of the Household.

  Abstract: This paper evaluates the causal impact of women's exposure to the internet on their attitudes towards intimate partner violence (IPV) using data from the most recent round of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5). To address potential endogeneity, we exploit exogenous variation in district-level mobile tower density in India as an instrument for women's internet exposure. The instrumental variables estimation provides robust evidence that a woman's exposure to internet reduces her likelihood of justifying IPV by 21 percentage points. We also provide suggestive evidence that higher awareness and physical mobility are potential mechanisms through which internet exposure shapes attitudes. Our findings highlight the transformative potential of digital connectivity in challenging regressive gender norms.

- **The Protective Power of Connectivity: Internet Exposure and Intimate Partner Violence**
  (with Dr. Gaurav Dhamija and Dr. Manini Ojha)
  Under Review

  Abstract: We study the effect of women's exposure to the internet on the incidence of intimate partner violence (IPV) utilizing data from a large-scale nationally representative data for India. Utilizing an instrumental variable approach, we exploit the exogenous variation arising from cellular tower density at the district level as an instrument for internet exposure. We find women who have access to the internet are at a significantly lower risk of exposure to physical, sexual, emotional and any IPV by 17, 5, 9 and 18 percentage points. We provide further indicative evidence that women's attitudes justifying violence works as a channel of our estimated causal impacts. Our results are robust to a host of sensitivity

checks, additional controls, alternative definitions and falsification analysis. We document important heterogeneity in the effects across social groups, wealth index, area of residence, and women's education levels. The effects appear to be particularly important for women who are more educated and for those belonging to the backward social groups.

- **Banking on Connectivity: Internet Exposure and Women's Financial Autonomy**

  (with Dr. Gaurav Dhamija and Dr. Manini Ojha)
  Under Review

  Abstract: We examine whether women's exposure to the internet enhances their economic agency in India. Using nationally representative data and an instrumental variables strategy that exploits plausibly exogenous variation in district-level mobile tower density, we identify the causal effect of internet access on women's financial control and use of formal banks. We find that internet exposure increases women's overall financial autonomy by 10 percentage points. We document improvements in independent mobility, employment, and financial awareness which we consider potential mechanisms of our estimated effects. Disaggregated outcomes show higher likelihood that women have money of their own over which they full control, as well as increased ownership and active use of a bank account. Our results are robust to additional controls and a battery of sensitivity analyses. Heterogeneity analyses indicate that effects are concentrated among women with at least secondary education, and among those from historically disadvantaged social groups. Overall, our findings highlight the importance of digital connectivity in enhancing the usage of financial resources, with important implications for women's autonomy and participation in the formal economy.

- **Knot Too Early: The Causal Impact of Women's Age at Marriage on Period Product Use**
  (with Dr. Gaurav Dhamija and Dr. Karan Babbar)
  Under Review

  Abstract: Despite significant progress in recent years, inadequate menstrual health and hygiene (MHH) remains a critical public health challenge in India, with approximately 30 percent of women aged 15-24 continuing to rely on cloth, rags, or nothing during menstruation. This paper examines whether delaying marriage can improve the menstrual health outcomes by estimating the causal effect of women's age at marriage on their use of period products. Using nationally representative data from India's National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5, 2019-21), we address endogeneity concerns by instrumenting age at marriage with age at menarche, a largely biologically determined factor that strongly predicts marriage timing in settings where daughters are married soon after attaining reproductive maturity. Our instrumental variable estimates reveal that delaying marriage by one year increases the probability of using period products by 7 percentage points (pp). This result is robust to alternative outcome specifications, sample restrictions, and falsification tests. We provide suggestive evidence that the effect operates through two key mechanisms: increased educational attainment and enhanced household decision-making power. Heterogeneity analysis reveals that effects are concentrated among socioeconomically disadvantaged groups, particularly women from backward castes and rural areas. These findings suggest that policies aimed at delaying child marriage, including stricter enforcement of existing laws and expan-

sion of conditional cash transfer programs, may yield meaningful improvements in menstrual health outcomes, particularly for disadvantaged populations.

- **From Liquor to LPG: Spillover effects of alcohol prohibition on clean fuel adoption**(with Dr. Gaurav Dhamija and Dr. Manini Ojha)
  Under Review

  Abstract: This paper examines whether a complete alcohol prohibition policy generates spillover effects on household adoption of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) as a primary cooking fuel, using Bihar's alcohol ban policy of 2016. Although clean cooking lies outside the policy's intended scope, prohibition may affect fuel choice by altering household expenditure patterns and intra-household dynamics. Using repeated cross-sectional data from the Household Consumption Expenditure Surveys (HCES) of 2011–12 and 2023–24, we implement a propensity score matching difference-in-differences design, comparing Bihar with Jharkhand. We estimate that the prohibition increased primary LPG adoption by 12.8 percentage points. The effect is concentrated in rural areas and is robust to alternative estimators, sample restrictions, and falsification tests. We further discuss that this spillover operates through reduced alcohol spending that relaxes the budget constraint for recurring LPG use and improved women's intra-household agency following prohibition. The results highlight that policies aimed at curbing socially costly consumption can generate broader welfare gains in unexpected domains, including clean energy adoption.

- **The Long Shadow of Communal Violence: Childhood Exposure and Later-Life Mental Health** (with Reetika Sindhi and Dr. Gaurav Dhamija)

  Abstract: Violent conflict affects millions of children worldwide, and much of it takes the form not of war but of short, localized communal violence whose long-run costs are rarely measured. We examine the long-run relationship between childhood exposure to Hindu–Muslim riots and women's mental health in India by linking historical riot records from 1950–1990 to respondents' childhood districts in the Longitudinal Ageing Study in India, exploiting variation in exposure across childhood districts and birth cohorts. Exposure to at least one riot between birth and age 14 is associated with a 2.4 percentage point increase in the probability of major depressive disorder in later life, 29 percent of the sample mean. The association runs through whether a woman was exposed at all: additional days of rioting add little, so even a single day of violence in a child's district is associated with depression decades later. Exposure is also associated with a higher probability of child marriage, a potential life-course channel. These findings extend evidence on the lasting mental-health consequences of armed conflict to localized, short-lived communal violence.

WORK IN PROGRESS

- **Causal Impact of Internet Exposure on Period Products Usage in India**

CONFERENCE PAPER PRESENTATIONS

- Research Symposium on Finance and Economics XXI International Conference on Public Policy and Management at the Centre for Public Policy (CPP), IIM Bangalore 2026
- Research Symposium on Finance and Economics (RSFE), Krea University 2026
- Peace and Conflict (PAC) Workshop, Plaksha University 2026
- IIM Calcutta Economics Research Conference 2026
- Second CDS PhD Colloquium – Crossroads 2026
- 7th Annual Conference of Economics & Finance (ACEF), BITS Pilani, Hyderabad Campus
- 7th Annual Economics Conference, Ahmedabad University
- 35th Annual Conference on Development Economics, Jadavpur University
- XXX IIPS National Seminar, Thiruvananthapuram 2025
- "Two Days National Conference on Women @ 75: Work, Life and Freedom, 2023" – ICSSR, UNICEF, and NIT Rourkela.
- "Graduate Research Meet" – School of Liberal Arts, IIT Jodhpur.
- XXI Bhopal Seminar 2023 – Contemporary Issues in Demography and Development in India.
- D.R. Gadgil Memorial Paper Presentation 2023 – Gokhale Institute of Politics and Economics.

FELLOWSHIP

- Ministry of Education Fellowship – Government of India — July 2024- July 2029
- Qualified for Assistant Professor – University Grants Commission — June 2023
  National Eligibility Test (UGC–NET) — December 2023

TECHNICAL SKILLS

STATA, QGIS, MS Office, LaTeX, Python (Basic), R (Basic)

LANGUAGES

Bengali, English , Hindi